Lhasa, who was later executed. This made Lhabsang Khan the king of Tibet in fact as well as in title.

In 1705 the emperor of China sent an envoy to Lhasa and recognized Lhabsang Khan as the king of Tibet under the protection of the Qing Dynasty. By agreeing to pay a regular tribute to the Qing, Lhabsang Khan placed himself (and, by extension, Tibet) in a subordinate relationship with China.

The drama was to continue. With complete military control over Tibet, Lhabsang Khan deposed Tsayang Gyatso by sending him into exile in Peking and placed another monk in his place who came to be known as the ‘Fake Dalai Lama’. Tsayang Gyatso in the meantime died en route to Peking and a rumour spread through Tibet that he had manifested in a new body in Litang in the Kham district. Resentment against Lhabsang Khan continued to grow, and in 1717 the monks of the three major monasteries around Lhasa asked their Mongol followers, the Dzungars, for help. Seven thousand cavalry, aided by scores of Tibetans, then moved on Lhasa and Lhabsang Khan was killed in the fighting. However, the Dzungars also fell out with the Tibetans by looting and executing some Red Hat lamas and failing to bring back the Litang Lama despite having killed the ‘Fake Dalai Lama’.

It wasn’t just the British who viewed Tibet as a buffer between India and Russia; the Chinese emperor had also seen the Himalayan kingdom as an important buffer between various regions of Western China—Szechuan, Gansu and Yunnan. Kang-Hsi, the Qing emperor, quickly took the Litang Lama under his control and sent an army to wrest control back from the Dzungars. The mobile Mongols annihilated this Qing force and though most Chinese court officials were apprehensive about any further military operations in Tibet, the emperor dispatched a larger army, sending the newly anointed seventh Dalai Lama (Kelzang Gyatso, the Litang Lama—then fifteen years old) with them. By October 1720, the Qing emperor had defeated those opposing him and had complete control over Tibet.

However, the Chinese were not particularly interested in administratively absorbing Tibet into China. Instead, Kang-Hsi created a loose protectorate over Tibet: the Qing Dynasty would protect Tibet from any external and internal threat, and would allow Tibetan leaders it approved of to rule in a manner that was not inimical to Chinese interests.